

ON THE HOUSE

The UPA's inability to push through legislation is a fallout of its reluctance to face parliamentary debate on crucial issues thereby making the 14th Lok Sabha the least functional in history



■ By Shafi Rahman

Exasperated by constant interruptions by the members from Kerala during the abruptly-adjourned monsoon session of Parliament, Speaker Somnath Chatterjee admonished them for repeatedly raising state-specific issues. "This is not the Kerala Assembly," he said, emphasising that better behaviour was expected from them. If the Speaker was referring to the Kerala state Assembly's record, as believed by some CPI(M) MPs, he could not have been more off the mark.

In comparison to the 14th Lok Sabha (which was marked by deadlock than debate), the Kerala Assembly has been an exemplar of parliamentary democracy, functioning with verve and responsibility. It met for 46 days this year, as against the Parliament which has met for 36 days so far. The Question Hour has never been called off due to pandemonium, while in Parliament, a robust Question Hour is more of an exception rather than the rule. The state Assembly met for an average of eight hours daily, as against six hours in the Lok Sabha.

It wasn't always like this. The downward slide of the Indian Parliament reached an uneasy climax during the last session when in a desperate bid to thwart a possible no-confidence motion, the Government did away with the winter session. The disqualification of some MPs who cross-voted during the July 22 trust vote had left the Government unsure of its majority and this explains the alacrity with which the session was brought to an end.

The recent session itself came after a long hiatus following the acrimonious

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